Any Day Now — Growth & Funding Plan

Oct 21, 2026 · @stevie

For Stevie McLane, founder of anydaynow.net. Researched 2026-10-21; the plan starts Thursday, Oct 22, 2026.

How to read this. It's written for a solo student founder with a small budget, so it favors free moves first. Every deadline and price was checked on the web on Oct 21, 2026, and links are in the Sources section. Anything marked **(unverified)** came from a third-party site or couldn't be confirmed on the official page, so check it before you rely on it. Nothing here has been posted, sent, signed up for or changed on the site.

The three things that matter most in the next 30 days:

1. Turn on measurement this week. Without numbers, every channel and every application below is weaker.
2. Apply to Y Combinator Winter 2027 by **Nov 2, 8pm PT**. It costs nothing, and a rejection still gets you a feedback loop.
3. Ride the holiday shipping peak (Black Friday is Nov 27, 2026). That's when people worry most about where their packages are.

1. Measurement first

Investors, judges and press will all ask the same question: how many people use it, and do they come back? Right now the site can't answer it. Fix that first; everything else in this plan depends on it.

Pick a tool

Option	Cost	Good at	Gap
Cloudflare Web Analytics	Free	Visits, pages, referrers, countries, Core Web Vitals. One toggle in the Cloudflare Pages dashboard, no cookies.	No custom events, so it can't count lookups or saves on its own.

Option	Cost	Good at	Gap
Cloudflare Workers Analytics Engine	Free tier: 100,000 data points written a day, 3-month retention	Server-side event counts from the Functions you already run: lookups, saves, sign-ins, alerts.	You query it with SQL; there's no ready-made dashboard.
Plausible	From about $9/month (Starter, 10k pageviews), 30-day free trial	Goals, custom events and funnels in a clean dashboard you can screenshot for a pitch deck. Cookieless.	Paid. Several sources list shared public dashboards on a higher tier **(unverified)**.

Recommendation: Turn on Cloudflare Web Analytics today, since it's free and takes one click. Then add Analytics Engine events inside the existing Pages Functions, because product events belong on the server where they can't be blocked by ad blockers. Move to Plausible only if you want a polished dashboard to show investors. Either way, add one line to the privacy page saying what's measured.

Adding events is a small code change. Do it in its own Claude session when you're ready; this plan doesn't touch the site.

What to track

Event	Why it matters	Where it comes from
Tracking lookup (with carrier and success or fail)	Core usage. The fail rate shows where carrier coverage needs work.	Lookup Function
Package saved	Shows intent to come back	Save endpoint / D1
Sign-in (email code, Google, GitHub)	Conversion from casual visitor to user	Auth Functions
Alert turned on (push or email)	The strongest retention signal: they want you to reach them	Push / email subscribe endpoints

Event	Why it matters	Where it comes from
Forward-to-track email received	Usage of a feature competitors make harder	track@ email Worker
Language chosen	Proves the 45-language claim with real use	Language picker
Return visit (same browser or account within 7 and 30 days)	Retention, the number investors care about most	Anonymous first-seen date in local storage, or account
Source (referrer and `?ref=` tag)	Which channel actually works	Web Analytics referrers + ref tags on every link you post

Your one headline number: packages actively tracked per week. Report it every week alongside week-1 and week-4 return rates. Tag every link you post (for example `anydaynow.net/?ref=reddit`) so you can tell channels apart.

2. Positioning

Category

Consumer logistics tech, specifically the **post-purchase experience**: everything between "order placed" and "package in hand." App-store category: Utilities. Industry code NAICS 513210 (software publishers).

One-liner

> **Any Day Now tells you where your package is and when it will really arrive, in plain words and in your language.**

A mobile app first, with a full desktop version. Free, and no account is needed to look something up.

What sets it apart

- **Plain language in 45 languages.** Carrier statuses like "Arrival at Unit" or "Departed from sorting center" become a sentence anyone understands. Helpful for international shoppers and families who don't read English first.
- **Honest delivery estimates.** On a real USPS test package, the estimate matched USPS's own date. That's one data point, so say "in our tests" until you have more. Start an **estimate accuracy log** now (predicted date vs. actual, per carrier). After 50–100 packages it becomes your strongest claim and a great press and Hacker News hook.
- **Route map.** You can see where the package has been, not just a list of scans.
- **Calm alerts.** Push and email only when something changes that matters. This is a real contrast with apps that ping constantly.
- **Forward-to-track.** Forward a shipping email to track@anydaynow.net and it's tracked, with no copy-and-paste.

Competitors (be fair, don't attack)

Competitor	What they are	How to position against them
17TRACK	Very wide carrier coverage, popular with AliExpress and Temu shoppers; also sells a business API	"Same packages, explained in plain words, without the clutter."
Parcel	Polished Apple-only app; premium is about $4.99/year in the US (varies by country)	"Works on any phone and on the web, free."
AfterShip	Mainly a tool for merchants (branded tracking pages, notifications), with a consumer app	Avoid head-on. It's a possible later B2B angle for you.
Route	Package protection sold at checkout, plus a tracking app funded by merchants	"No insurance upsell. Just tracking."

Check each competitor's current features and prices before quoting them anywhere public. Only the Parcel price above was checked, and it comes from app-store listings.

The question investors will ask: how does it make money?

AdSense alone won't be venture-scale. Have an honest answer ready with two or three experiments, not a finished model. For example: an optional paid tier (Parcel shows people pay about $5/year), affiliate or retailer partnerships, or a white-label tracking page for small online stores (AfterShip's market). Saying "I'll test these once I see retention numbers" is a fine answer at this stage.

3. Launch and marketing channels

Ranked by effort versus payoff for one person with almost no budget. Do them roughly in this order.

Rank	Channel	Effort	Cost	Likely payoff	When
1	Reddit, as a helpful answerer	Low, ongoing	Free	Medium–high, steady	Start now
2	SEO help pages	Medium, once per page	Free	High but slow (months)	Start now
3	Short video (TikTok, Reels, Shorts)	Low (the reel exists)	Free	Spiky, could break out	From week 2
4	Show HN	Medium, one day	Free	One-day spike, great feedback	Mid-November
5	Product Hunt	Medium–high	Free	One-day spike, a badge for credibility	Early December
6	Press (local and student)	Medium	Free	Credibility for applications	Holiday season
7	Paid ads	Low	Money	Unknown	Not until retention is measured

Reddit

The biggest free opportunity. People post "my package is stuck in customs" every day.

- Communities to look at: the AliExpress, Temu and Shein subreddits, plus USPS and general package-tracking ones. Check that each exists, and read its self-promotion rules before posting anything.
- Play: answer real questions well, and link a help page only when it truly answers the question. Say openly that you built it. Common practice is to keep promotion to a small share of your activity.

- One "I built a free tracker that explains statuses in plain English (and 44 other languages)" post per community, only where the rules allow it, after you've been helpful there for a couple of weeks.
- Tag links `?ref=reddit`.

SEO help pages

You already have four help pages and a sitemap. Help pages are how people find a tracker when they're worried, so grow them on purpose.

- Set up **Google Search Console** and **Bing Webmaster Tools** (both free) and submit the sitemap. This is the first step.
- Write one page per common confusing status or worry. Examples: "Temu package stuck in customs: how long?", "AliExpress tracking not updating", "USPS 'In Transit, Arriving Late' meaning", "Cainiao status meanings explained", "Package says delivered but isn't here."
- Your edge is language: translated versions of the best pages can rank in markets English trackers ignore.
- Every page ends with the lookup box. Write for people, not keywords.

Short video

The finished reel is at `C:\Users\stevi\Desktop\adn-video\out\AnyDayNow-Reel4-9x16.mp4` (37.7 s, 9:16).

- Post it natively on TikTok, Instagram Reels and YouTube Shorts. Don't post the same file with another app's watermark.
- Cut 3–4 shorter versions (10–15 s), each opening on one pain: "stuck in customs," "tracking in a language you can't read," "says delivered, isn't here." The motion-reel skill can cut these.
- Aim for about three posts a week, and reply to every comment. Put the link in your bio with `?ref=tiktok` and so on.

Show HN (Hacker News)

- Rules: it must be something people can try right away, ideally without signing up (yours works without an account, which helps). You must have built it and be there to answer questions. Never ask anyone to upvote.
- Title idea: "Show HN: Any Day Now – package tracking in plain language, 45 languages."

- Lead with the build: Cloudflare Pages, D1 and Workers AI, how the plain-language translation works, and how you make estimates honest. Be upfront about the AdSense ads; HN readers notice them.
- Post on a weekday morning US time, then stay at your desk for six hours to answer comments.

Product Hunt

- Product Hunt's day starts at 12:01am PT. Guides say only a small share of launches get featured (about 10% in one source, **unverified**). Don't ask for upvotes; Product Hunt warns against it.
- Prepare: gallery images (export stills from the reel), the 16:9 reel, a short maker comment telling your story, and a first-comment FAQ.
- Launch on a Tuesday–Thursday in early December, after you've learned from Show HN.

Press angles

- **Student founder:** "UNT student builds a free package tracker that speaks 45 languages." Pitch UNT News, the North Texas Daily, Dallas Innovates and the Denton Record-Chronicle.
- **Holiday shipping:** "How to tell when your holiday package will really arrive." Pitch in mid-to-late November with your accuracy numbers.
- **Customs confusion:** the US ended the duty-free (de minimis) exemption for low-value imports in 2025, and more cheap overseas orders now sit in customs. Confirm the current rule before using this angle **(unverified here)**.
- Keep a one-page press kit on the About page: logo, screenshots, the reel, a 100-word description and your contact.

Paid ads

Hold off. Until you know week-4 retention, paid installs just pay for people who leave. Later, a $50 test on Reddit or TikTok aimed at one help-page topic is a cheap way to learn.

4. Funding paths for a student founder

Order of realism: university money and competitions first (non-dilutive, made for students), then accelerators (free to apply, long shots, but the application itself sharpens your story), then grants, then angels once you have traction numbers.

Path	What you get	What it needs	Timeline	Fit
UNT Breakthrough Ventures (Murphy Center, fall)	2025 top prize was $14,000–$15,000 (sources differ)	Any UNT undergrad or grad student. 2025 categories were Healthcare & Life Sciences, Deep Tech and Social Impact.	**Closed.** 2026 applications closed Oct 23. First-round awards Oct 26, video due Nov 6, final Nov 19.	Medium. A Social Impact pitch (45 languages, immigrant and non-English-reading shoppers) could work. Email the Murphy Center this week.
Innovate UNT (iUNT) pitch competition (spring)	$35,000 in cash and in-kind prizes (2026 cycle)	Business-model write-up, a video and a live pitch with interviews	**Not open yet.** The 2026 round ran Jan 20 – Mar 19 (finals Apr 17). Spring 2027 expected to open in January **(unverified)**.	**High.** This is your best near-term target. The reel covers the video.
Murphy Center support (StartupTree, mentors, Denton Angels)	Mentors, introductions, a UNT-linked angel group	Sign up on UNT's StartupTree; ask for office hours	**Open now.** Ongoing: sign up at unt-murphy-center.startuptree.co.	High. Free, and it builds the relationships behind the competitions.
Y Combinator, Winter 2027	Standard deal about $500k (check ycombinator.com/deal) plus the batch in San Francisco	Online application, a 1-minute founder video, a demo. No company needed to apply. Solo founders can be accepted.	**Open now. Deadline Nov 2, 2026, 8pm PT.** Decisions by Dec 11. Batch runs Jan–Mar 2027. Late applications are read, without a set reply date. Apply	Long shot, but free. Apply.
a16z speedrun, SR008	Investment (amount and terms: check the official page)	Online application	**Done: applied and rejected** (SR008). Applications are reviewed year-round, so a later cohort is possible once there's traction.	Low–medium. It's focused on games and consumer tech. Optional.

Path	What you get	What it needs	Timeline	Fit
Techstars, Spring 2027	$220,000 investment (one source)	Online application; programs vary by city	**Open now. Deadline Nov 18, 2026** (news reports; confirm at apply.techstars.com). Programs Mar 8 – Jun 3, 2027. Late applications go to a general pool. No Texas program listed.	Medium. A good second shot if YC says no.
Emergent Ventures (Mercatus Center)	Grants that vary in size; rolling	A proposal of up to 1,500 words. **It must be your own writing:** the official page says AI-written applications are tested for and rejected.	**Open now.** Rolling, no deadline. Apply. One application per person and project.	Medium. Write it yourself.
1517 Fund Medici Project	$1,000 student micro-grant **(unverified)**	Reportedly a short video emailed in **(unverified)**	**Open now.** Rolling. The form is filled in Chrome and waiting for your review; not sent.	Medium, and fast.
Eclipse grants	$5,000 for founders under 25 **(unverified)**	Not confirmed	**Not open yet.** Run by Moth Fund; the official page says "Soon!" with an email to hear more.	Check the official page.
NSF SBIR Phase I	Federal R&D grant	A US small business, real technical risk and research, SAM.gov registration, an accepted Project Pitch first	**Not open to us yet.** Full proposals need a Project Pitch invitation, a company and SAM.gov (up to 3 weeks). Deadlines Nov 4, 2026 and Mar 4, 2027 (official page); Mar 4 is the realistic one.	**Low for now.** A consumer tracker is a weak fit unless there's genuine research (for example, a new delivery-date prediction model). Revisit later.

Path	What you get	What it needs	Timeline	Fit
Angels (Denton Angels, North Texas Angel Network, Cowtown Angels)	Typically $25k–$250k on a SAFE (typical range, not checked)	Accredited investors. They expect a company, a deck and traction numbers.	**Not yet.** No application; approach after 60–90 days of data.	Medium, later. Ask the Murphy Center for a warm introduction.
Founder Institute Dallas	Pre-seed program and network	Application; usually a program fee **(unverified)**	**Closed in Dallas.** No open Dallas cohort (page is stale, $799 fee). Austin Fall 2026 closes Nov 17; virtual Healthtech closes Oct 27 ($1,399).	Low. It costs money.

Before you take anyone's money

- **Check who owns the code.** Read UNT's intellectual property policy. Student projects built on your own time and equipment are usually yours, but confirm it before an investor asks.
- **Form a company only when you need one.** You can apply to YC, Techstars and competitions without one. Accepting investment usually means a Delaware C-corporation (services like Stripe Atlas or Clerky set one up for a few hundred dollars, **unverified price**). A Texas LLC is cheaper but isn't what investors expect.
- **Keep a clean data room:** your metrics sheet, the deck, a one-page summary, and the privacy and terms pages.
- **Never pay to apply or pitch.** Watch for third-party sites that offer to submit applications for you for a fee.

5. Claude plugins and connectors, and what Stevie must do themself

What to use for each part

Part of the plan	Plugin or skill	Status in your setup	Use it for
Measurement	**Marketing** → `performance-report`; **Hyper Marketing** → `analytics-insights`	Installed	Weekly metrics write-up. The Amplitude connector needs sign-in via `/mcp` if you use it.
Positioning	**Marketing** → `competitive-brief`, `brand-review`; **venture** → `competitors`, `pmf`, `model`	Marketing installed; **venture is available but not installed** (community plugin)	Competitor teardown, business-model options, a devil's-advocate check
Reddit, short video	**Hyper Marketing** → `reddit`, `tiktok`, `instagram`, `youtube`; **motion-reel** for new cuts	Installed; the HyperFX connector needs sign-in via `/mcp`	Drafting posts and captions, short cuts of the reel
SEO	**Marketing** → `seo-audit`, `content-creation`; **Hyper Marketing** → `seo-research`, `blog-generation`	Installed; Ahrefs and Similarweb connectors need sign-in via `/mcp`	Choosing help-page topics and drafting pages
Launches and press	**Marketing** → `campaign-plan`, `draft-content`; **marketing-ideas** → `idea-ranking`	Installed	Show HN and Product Hunt copy, press pitches, a launch-day plan

Part of the plan	Plugin or skill	Status in your setup	Use it for
Ethics check	**marketing-psychology** → `dark-pattern-check`	Installed	Keeps "calm alerts" honest; checks sign-up and notification prompts
Pitch deck	**Pitch Deck Advisor**	Installed	Deck v1 and v2, a red-flag review before you send it
Investors	**venture-capital-intelligence**	**Available but not installed** (community plugin)	Screening which angels and funds fit; prep notes on each

To add **venture** and **venture-capital-intelligence**, install them from the plugin directory in the Claude app. Both are community-made, so skim what they do before you install them.

What Stevie does themself (Claude can't or shouldn't)

- **Sign-ins and accounts:** creating accounts on Product Hunt, Hacker News, Reddit, TikTok, Instagram and YouTube, Google Search Console and Bing; connecting Claude connectors via `/mcp`.
- **Posting:** approving and publishing every post, video, comment and launch, and replying to people. Claude drafts; you post.
- **Applications:** submitting YC, Techstars, speedrun, UNT and grant applications, and recording founder videos. Write the Emergent Ventures one entirely yourself.
- **Anything involving money:** analytics subscriptions, ads, incorporation fees, bank accounts, signing a SAFE or any agreement, and AdSense settings.
- **Emails to real people:** press, Murphy Center staff, investors. Claude can draft them; you send them.

6. 30/60/90-day checklist

Dates start Thursday, Oct 22, 2026. Holiday anchors: Thanksgiving Nov 26, Black Friday Nov 27, Cyber Monday Nov 30.

Days 1–30 (Oct 22 – Nov 21): measure, apply, start the free channels

- [x] ~~**Oct 22:** Turn on Cloudflare Web Analytics in the Pages dashboard.~~

- [x] ~~**Oct 22:** Email the Murphy Center (murphycenter@unt.edu): is Breakthrough Ventures 2026 still open, and when does iUNT 2027 open? Join UNT's StartupTree.~~
- [x] ~~**Oct 23, 11:59pm (deadline): Breakthrough Ventures 2026 is open.** Draft answers to all six essays are filled in on StartupTree, with the category set to Social Impact. Before you press Submit Entry: replace [ID] and [UNT email] in question 2, check questions 3–6, and confirm the cost estimates in Team & capital; then Save Draft.~~
- [x] ~~**Oct 23:** Google Search Console done (verified through Cloudflare DNS, sitemap submitted Oct 22). Bing Webmaster Tools done (imported from Google, sitemap submitted Oct 22).~~
- [x] ~~**Oct 23–26:** Done Oct 22: added events (lookups, saves, sign-ins, alerts, forward-to-track, language) with Analytics Engine, and a line on the privacy page.~~
- [x] ~~**Oct 24:** Start the estimate accuracy log (spreadsheet: carrier, predicted date, actual date).~~
- [ ] **Oct 24–29:** Draft the YC application. Record the 1-minute founder video and a 2-minute demo.
- [x] ~~**Nov 1:** Optional: submit a16z speedrun SR008.~~
- [ ] **Oct 31 (target), Nov 2 8pm PT (hard deadline):** Submit YC Winter 2027.
- [ ] **Nov 2–8:** Start answering Reddit questions (no links in the first week). Cut 3–4 short versions of the reel.
- [ ] **Nov 4 onward:** Post short videos about three times a week on TikTok, Reels and Shorts.
- [ ] **Nov 9–13:** Write two new help pages (Temu/AliExpress customs delays; "tracking not moving for days").
- [ ] **Nov 16:** Submit Techstars Spring 2027 (deadline Nov 18).
- [ ] **Tue Nov 17:** Show HN. Block out the day to reply.
- [ ] **Nov 18–20:** Pitch the holiday-shipping story to UNT News, the North Texas Daily and Dallas Innovates.
- [ ] **Nov 21 (day 30):** First metrics review: weekly tracked packages, return rates, best channel.

Days 31–60 (Nov 22 – Dec 21): the holiday peak

- [ ] **Nov 23–25:** Publish a "holiday shipping deadlines and what statuses mean" help page before Thanksgiving.
- [ ] **Nov 27 – Dec 1:** Black Friday / Cyber Monday: heavier video and Reddit presence, all answer-first.

- [ ] **Dec 1:** Build pitch deck v1 with Pitch Deck Advisor, using real numbers.
- [ ] **Tue Dec 8 (or Dec 1):** Product Hunt launch.
- [ ] **Dec 1–11:** Write and send your Emergent Ventures application (your own words), and the 1517 Medici application if it's confirmed open.
- [ ] **By Dec 11:** YC decision arrives. If yes, follow their next steps. If no, read any feedback and keep going.
- [ ] **Dec 14–18:** Publish the first accuracy results once you have 50+ packages: a help page or blog post, and a press follow-up.
- [ ] **Dec 21 (day 60):** Second metrics review. Choose the two best channels; drop the rest.

Days 61–90 (Dec 22, 2026 – Jan 20, 2027): returns season, competitions, investors

- [ ] **Dec 22 – Jan 5:** Returns-season content ("tracking a return") and translated versions of the top two help pages.
- [ ] **Early January:** Apply to Innovate UNT 2027 as soon as it opens; use the reel as the video.
- [ ] **Early January:** Pitch deck v2 and a one-page summary. Red-flag review with Pitch Deck Advisor.
- [ ] **January:** Ask the Murphy Center for introductions to Denton Angels; use venture-capital-intelligence to prepare a short list.
- [ ] **January:** Start a monthly investor and mentor update email (metrics, what shipped, one ask).
- [ ] **January:** Decide on one revenue experiment from Positioning, to test in February.
- [ ] **Jan 20 (day 90):** Third review. Decide: keep bootstrapping with competition prize money, or raise a small angel round.

Budget

Item	Cost
Cloudflare Web Analytics, Analytics Engine (free tier), Search Console, Bing, Reddit, HN, Product Hunt, short-video platforms	$0
Plausible (optional)	About $9/month

Item	Cost
Applications to YC, Techstars, speedrun, UNT competitions, grants	$0
Incorporation (only when taking investment)	A few hundred dollars **(unverified)**
Paid ads test (only after day 60, only if retention looks good)	About $50

Sources

Checked Oct 21, 2026. Third-party sources are marked; confirm before you rely on them.

- Y Combinator: Apply; Winter 2027 deadline and decision dates via Roundfunded and Venture Capital Tracker (third-party)
- a16z speedrun: Apply page
- Techstars Spring 2027: Technext24 (third-party)
- UNT: Murphy Center, Innovate UNT, Breakthrough Ventures, 2025 results, UNT News 2026, Denton Angels
- Emergent Ventures: Mercatus Center; 1517 and Eclipse micro-grants via Equity-free money guide (third-party)
- NSF SBIR: Deadlines 2026, Reauthorization (third-party); confirm on seedfund.nsf.gov
- DFW angels: Betaboom DFW guide, North Texas Angel Network, Founder Institute Dallas
- Analytics: Cloudflare Web Analytics limits, Analytics Engine pricing, Analytics Engine limits; Plausible pricing via Toolpick (third-party; confirm on plausible.io)
- Launches: Show HN guidelines; Product Hunt via Innmind playbook (third-party)
- Parcel pricing: App listing via AppFollow (third-party)